

THE LAST MESSAGE

By Ivan Lewis

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INT. BATHROOM - DAY

Steam clouds a bathroom mirror.

A SHOWER runs.

From somewhere beyond the door – thin, tinny music bleeds in.
Bright. Cheerful. Then it shifts.

A WOMAN'S VOICE. Warm. Bedtime-soft.
Each line spaced with a small, practiced pause.

VO

Solace.
Breathe in. We count it.
Breathe out. We keep it.
For goodbyes that come too fast.
For love when it gets messy.
We find the words. You hold the rest.
Solace – for you, with you, always.

A soft, signature chime.

The earlier music returns.

ALEX (late 30s/early 40s) shuts off the water.

He steps out. In a towel. Drips on tile.

On a counter: a small digital display
– date/time – easy to miss.

INT. BEDROOM / CLOSET - CONTINUOUS

Alex pulls open a crowded wardrobe.

He takes pants. Then a shirt.

He lifts the shirt to his face. Smells it. A pause.

He puts it on.

He searches for something inside the wardrobe. Shifts clothes.
Reaches past a stack of books.

He nudges a PHOTO FRAME lying face-down on a shelf.

It turns just enough: a little boy on a man's shoulders.

Alex stills.

He flips it face-down again. Keeps searching.

On the same shelf: a dusty PHOTO ALBUM. Warped pages.

A smiling face caught between them: DAD.

He finds his keys. Grabs them.

He shuts the wardrobe.

Too hard.

EXT. STREET / LOBBY / WALKWAY - DAY

Alex walks with a coffee, eyes on his phone. Not present.

A notification: DAD.

The thread is muted. Ignored. For months.

His thumb hovers. He opens it.

Messages flood up the screen – ordinary, small, lonely.

DAD (TEXT)
The newspaper came late.

DAD (TEXT)
Food is okay.

DAD (TEXT)
It rained today.

DAD (TEXT)
They fixed the fan.

Older, half-buried:

DAD (TEXT)
I signed the documents

DAD (TEXT)
We can talk when you come.

Alex scrolls past it.

A recent one:

DAD (TEXT)
They moved me to the window bed. More light.

Something loosens in Alex's face.

Then another message arrives – right then – and it's different.

DAD (TEXT)
I still relive that day. I'm sorry.

Alex stops walking.

His thumb starts a reply.

ALEX (TYPING – UNSENT)
Why now?

Delete.

ALEX (TYPING – UNSENT)
Are you

Delete.

ALEX (TYPING – UNSENT)
I can't.

He doesn't delete that one. He just stares at it.

The cursor blinks.

He locks the phone and pockets it.

Keeps walking.

INT. ELEVATOR - DAY

Corporate elevator. Mirrored walls. Soft hum. Floor numbers glowing.

The music is a familiar cheerful loop.

It shifts.

A fragment of the Solace voice slips in – like an elevator version of comfort.

SOLACE VO (O.S., MUFFLED/LOOPING)
...not perfect words. Just true ones...

Door chime. A hush as the doors seal.

SOLACE VO (O.S., MUFFLED/LOOPING)
...Solace – for you, with you... always...

Alex stares at his reflection.

Adjusts his collar. Stops.

INT. OFFICE / DESK - DAY

A clock: 6:45.

Alex's personal phone rings.

He lets it ring once. Twice.

He answers.

ALEX
Hello.

A voice — practiced kindness, clipped by routine.

CARE HOME STAFF (V.O.)
Hello? Is this Alex?

ALEX
Yes.

CARE HOME STAFF (V.O.)
This is Compassionate Care.
I'm calling about Mr. David Parish.

Alex grips the edge of his desk.

CARE HOME STAFF (V.O.)
He passed this evening.

Alex doesn't make a sound.

CARE HOME STAFF (V.O.)
It was calm. No pain.

A pause. Then, softer:

CARE HOME STAFF (V.O.)
He kept looking at his phone.

Alex swallows.

ALEX
Did he...

CARE HOME STAFF (V.O.)
He asked for you once.

A pause.

Then the staff member shifts into procedure.

CARE HOME STAFF (V.O.)
Would you like us to send his belongings,
or will you collect them?

Alex blinks.

A choice. Now.

ALEX
Send them.

CARE HOME STAFF (V.O.)
All right. We'll confirm by text.

Call ends.

Alex holds the phone a moment longer than necessary.

INT. APARTMENT - ONE WEEK LATER - DAY

A small BOX on a table.

Inside: spectacles. A comb. A folded beige sweater.
A photocopy of a signed release form.
A file from the "Compassionate Care."
A brochure: SOLACE - FOR YOU, WITH YOU, ALWAYS.
An enrollment card. A receipt.

On the receipt:

MESSAGE SUPPORT PLAN: ACTIVE
POST-INCIDENT ENROLLMENT: PAID

An analog WATCH sits on top of everything, ticking. Used as a paperweight.

The room is quiet enough to hear it.

INT. APARTMENT - DAYS LATER - DAY

The same table. The box hasn't moved.

The watch ticks.

Alex sits on the couch, not asleep, not awake. Just... present.

His phone pings.

A message.

From DAD.

DAD (TEXT)
It rained today.

Alex frowns. Looks out of the window.

Rain.

He looks back at the phone. The date stamp is today.

He scrolls up.

Another message arrives, almost on cue.

DAD (TEXT)
You don't have to reply. I just wanted you to see it.

Alex stares.

He checks the date stamp again.

Looks at the brochure.

SOLACE.

The watch ticks.

He picks up the brochure.

INT. APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS

Alex dials the number printed on the SOLACE brochure.

It rings once. Twice.

A calm, cheerful voice answers – practiced warmth.

SOLACE REP (V.O.)

Solace support. How can I help you today?

Alex opens his mouth.

Nothing comes out.

He tries again.

ALEX

My father... had an account.

SOLACE REP (V.O.)

Of course. I can help with that.
Do you have the enrollment number?

Alex looks at the card. His thumb rubs the edge.

ALEX

Yes.

SOLACE REP (V.O.)

Thank you. A branch can provide the full archive – printed or
digital. Whatever is easier.

Alex's eyes flick to the muted thread on his phone.

INT. SOLACE BRANCH – DAY

A space designed to lower your shoulders.

Quiet. Soft light. Clean surfaces. Not cold, but comforting.

A gentle playlist.

A token dispenser. A screen with numbers.

People sitting like they're waiting for help, not paperwork.

A CLERK looks up at Alex at the counter – bright, cheerful,
trained.

CLERK

Hi. How can I help you?

Alex slides over the death certificate and enrollment card.

ALEX

My father's account.

I need the archive.

Everything. Printed.

The clerk checks the card. Types.

CLERK

I'm sorry – are you listed as primary family contact?

Alex doesn't answer fast enough.

CLERK (CONT'D)

I can still process it. I'll just need an ID.

Alex hands it over.

The clerk scans it. Types again.

CLERK

Would you like the full archive, including blocked entries?

A small nod from Alex.

The clerk smiles, professional.

CLERK

All right. Please have a seat.

At the next counter, an older woman signs for a "PRINTED BIRTHDAY BUNDLE."

She smiles apologetically at the clerk.

The clerk smiles back – routine, kind.

Alex sits in a chair that's too bright, too designed.

The room is quiet.

Printing starts behind the desk: rhythmic, patient.

INT. SOLACE BRANCH - MOMENTS LATER

A stack of pages slides across the counter.

A header:

NAME: MR. DAVID PARISH

STATUS: ACTIVE

Columns: DATE / MODE / NOTE

Alex's eyes move down.

MODE repeats:

ORIGINAL
SUPPORTED
SUPPORTED
ORIGINAL
SUPPORTED

Alex looks up.

ALEX
What's "Mode"?

The clerk glances at the page.

CLERK
Message type. Original or Supported.

ALEX
Supported?

CLERK
Assisted phrasing.

Alex looks up.

ALEX
Meaning?

CLERK
If a sender has difficulty composing, we help format the
message.

Alex's gaze returns to the paper.

ALEX
So you wrote it?

The clerk shakes her head.

CLERK
No, sir.
We don't author messages.
We support clarity.

Alex gives a short laugh.

ALEX
And you never change meaning?

The clerk holds the smile. Doesn't answer.

Then, like offering a menu option—

CLERK
If you'd like, I can mark original entries.
Some families prefer that.

Alex doesn't answer. Then—

ALEX
Mark them.

The clerk takes a highlighter.

She marks one line — jagged, blunt.

DAD (ON PAPER — ORIGINAL)

Eat dinner.

Another.

DAD (ON PAPER — ORIGINAL)

Don't be late.

DAD (ON PAPER — ORIGINAL)

The tea here is terrible.

Then:

DAD (ON PAPER — SUPPORTED)

I miss you son. I don't know how to say it.

Alex reads it again. His jaw locks.

Just below, a line sits unhighlighted — original.

DAD (ON PAPER — ORIGINAL)

I signed.

This time, Alex goes still.

The clerk keeps sorting papers.

CLERK

He prepaid for five years.

Renewed before the first term ended.

Alex's voice is small now.

ALEX

Why is it still... active?

The clerk finally meets his eyes, kind.

CLERK

Family-thread support remains active unless cancelled.

It's part of the plan.

Alex nods.

Looks back at the paper.

INT. APARTMENT - NIGHT

The room is darker now. The table is the same.

Box. Watch ticking. The face-down frame. The low chair.

Alex sits on the couch with his phone.

He opens the Dad thread.

His thumbs hover.

He types.

ALEX (TYPING — UNSENT)
Why did you sign?

Delete.

ALEX (TYPING — UNSENT)
So now I am the bad son?

Delete.

ALEX (TYPING — UNSENT)
I hate you

He stares at it.

Delete.

A long pause.

He types again, slower.

ALEX (TYPING — UNSENT)
I saw the window bed.

He doesn't send it.

He looks at a low chair.

Walks to it. Sits.

Feels the wrong height.

Doesn't adjust.

CLOSE ON PHONE SCREEN - NIGHT

A prompt fills the screen:

DELETE ARCHIVE PERMANENTLY?

This will erase all records and cannot be undone.

Buttons:

CANCEL / DELETE

Alex's thumb hovers.

From somewhere through the wall – faint, muffled – the Solace chime.

That lullaby voice, barely there.

Alex's thumb trembles.

He presses DELETE.

A soft system tone.

INT. APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS

The phone buzzes.

A new message arrives in the same thread.

The same cadence.

DAD (TEXT)

You okay?

Alex stares.

He lifts the phone.

Frames himself in the low chair.

Takes the photo.

Sends it.

No caption.

A pause.

Then – a reaction appears on the image.

A thumbs-up.

Alex looks at the face-down frame.

He turns it upright.

Wipes the glass with his thumb.

Sets it down carefully.

He powers the phone off.

Not face-down.

Off.

Silence deepens.

We hold on the scene.

Through the wall – like a neighbor's TV left on – the familiar tune returns.

Then the soft voice. Almost affectionate.

SOLACE VO (O.S., MUFFLED)

Solace – for you, with you, always.

The watch ticks.

CUT TO BLACK.



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SWA Membership Number
65964

Co Authors (Pen Name)
-

Co Authors SWA Membership Numbers
-

Type of Creation - Screenplay

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Reference Number - 114323114154

Title of Creation - The Last Message

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